

MODALITY MATTERS?!

the effect of monomodal versus multimodal news coverage on party leader recall

Let's start with a quick memory game. Close your eyes, yes really, and think about the news you consumed last week. It can be a story you opened, scrolled through, or came across. Now - does a politician come to mind? What political actors were featured in the piece of news you are now thinking about?

Hold on to that thought... My question, today, is: how do you remember these politicians? Do you remember a face, a photo? A name, a headline, words, associations?

You can open your eyes now.

This study aims to investigate how the textual, visual and multimodal representation of politicians in news coverage affects our memory of those politicians. As these memories ultimately shape the way we think of politics and whom to vote for.

During a campaign and election period of three months in total, we tracked news coverage across four Dutch outlets, and coded whether politicians appeared visually, textually, or in both modalities.

We linked this to opinion data from a longitudinal panel, where respondents were asked: which politicians stood out to you in the news recently? This yielded a binary variable: 1 if the politician stood out, 0 if they didn't.

From Dual Coding theory, we expected that exposure to multimodal coverage of politicians would be the strongest positive predictor of a respondent's recall of that politician.

We found that modality matters; pure visual coverage did not increase the likelihood of a politician being recalled. Textual-only news coverage raised the odds of recalling the politician with 6%, and multimodal coverage raised those odds with 13%.

The image alone, hence, does not boost recall - the political meaning is embedded in language, and only when the visual appearance is accompanied by textual context, we find that multimodal coverage will make memorizing this politician more likely.

But that's not all we found.

The strongest predictor of recalling a politician this week, is whether you recalled that politician last week - our lagged dependent variable - at an odds ratio of 2,73. Yes, 2,73!

So, going back to our memory game... Chances are that the politician that came to your mind wasn't new to you - you were primed, or primed yourself, to recall them, regardless of what modality coverage they enjoyed in the news.

Political memory is sticky. There's much more to find out about its mechanisms, so let's have a discussion on how to untangle it.

Thank you.

